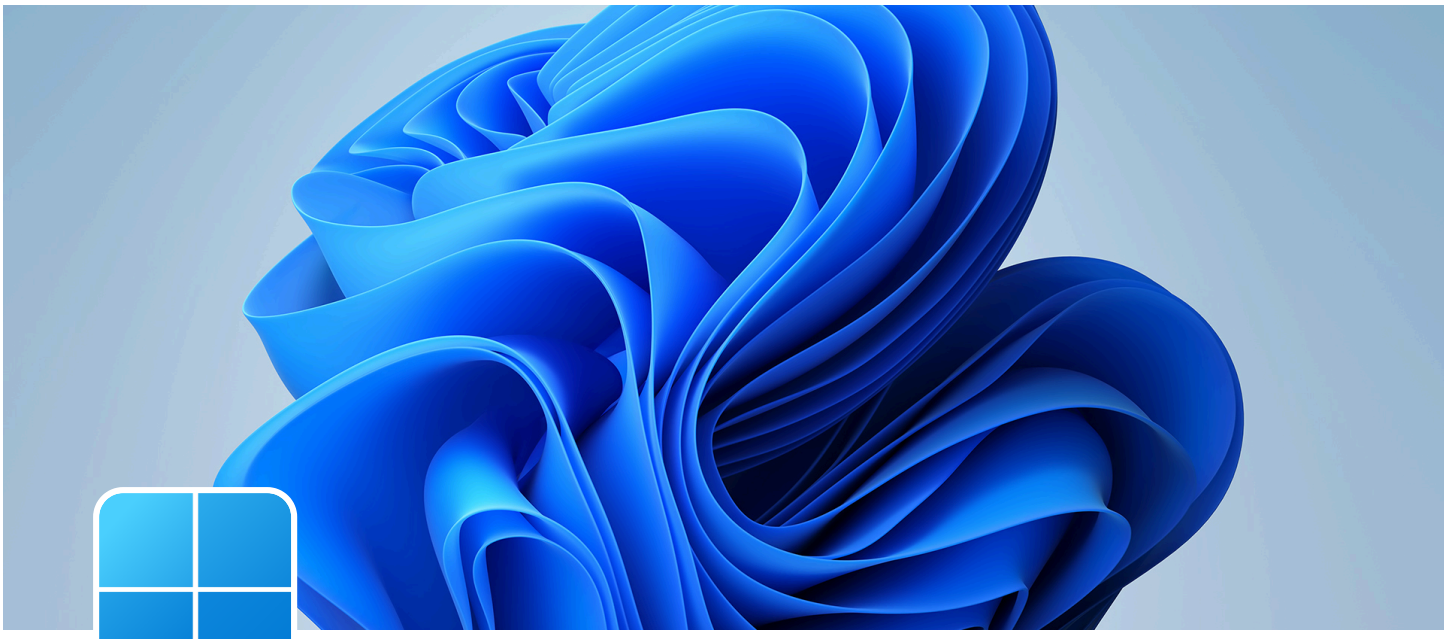

Clean Windows 11 Installation Guide

In this document, you'll find a step-by-step tutorial on how to install the latest version of Windows, and how to set it up correctly for minimal bloat.

Page • Work in Progress Tutorial • 1 backlink

> ℹ️ This document is still a work in progress!

This guide is for people wanting to install or reinstall Windows in a clean way. Basic computer knowledge is assumed, but for more technical parts, you'll find additional guides linked if you wish to learn more or make sure you are doing things correctly.

Windows installation

This may seem obvious, but if you want to debloat Windows, you need to install it first. If you installed it a while ago, I'd recommend installing it again from scratch to make sure everything I'll detail here will work normally.

Before starting, make sure you got everything listed below:

- A computer with Windows 10 or 11 ;
- A mass storage device (the one in your future Windows computer). Preferably an SSD, but an HDD would work ;
- A flash drive (also commonly called USB key) with at least 8GB of maximum capacity ;

- At least 128GB of storage and 8GB of RAM for most usages. Depending on what you will use your computer for, you may need more.

Preparing the installation

Downloading Windows

- Get on Microsoft's website's Windows download page ;
- Under "Download Windows 11 Disk Image (ISO) for x64 devices", select "Windows 11 (multi-edition ISO for x64 devices)", click "Confirm" ;
- Under "Select the product language", I'd recommend choosing "English International" if you're comfortable with it, else choose your preferred language. This tutorial will be oriented for English International ;
- Click "Confirm".
- Under "Download - Windows 11 English International" (or whichever language you chose), click "64-bit Download".

> ❗ The ISO file is very large! (> 7 GB) Make sure to be in proper conditions to download it.

Creating a bootable device

- Download the portable version of Rufus at https://rufus.ie/en/#download ;

> ℹ️ Rufus only works on Windows 8, 10, or 11. For people using MacOS or Linux, you can find similar tools online.

- You can run the executable file from basically anywhere in your computer. Run it ;
- Under "Device", select your flash drive ;
- Under "Boot selection", click on the "SELECT" button and select your downloaded ISO file ;
- In Rufus' window's bottom, click on "START" ;

> ❗ This will ERASE all data stored on the flash drive! Make sure to backup anything you wish to keep.

- An additional popup appears for more settings. I'd recommend activating "Remove requirement for 4GB+ RAM, ...", "Remove requirement for an online

Microsoft account", "Disable data collection", and "Disable BitLocker...", then click on "OK" ;

- A popup appears to confirm you wish to continue. If you are sure, click on "OK" ;
- Wait for the bootable device creation to finish. Once the Status bar indicates "READY", click on "CLOSE".

Preparing the computer

- Make sure the computer you will install Windows 11 on is:
  - turned off ;
  - disconnected from the internet ;
- Plug the flash drive into the fastest port you have. Discover how to recognize it here ;
- Plug in a keyboard. A mouse is optional (and may not even be supported).

Installing Windows

> ℹ️ It is optional but recommended to disconnect any extra drive you may have in your computer, if you can, before starting it, to prevent any issues when installing Windows.

Booting from BIOS/UEFI

- Turn on your computer and immediately start repeatedly pressing the Delete, F2, or F10 key (it depends of your computer, but is usually one of these three) ;
- Once in BIOS/UEFI, navigate to the boot order/boot priority section. This is usually found under tabs labeled "Boot", "Startup", or "Advanced" ;
- Move your flash drive to the top of the boot priority list. Use the on-screen instructions to help you ;
- Save changes and exit ;

Your computer will restart and should boot from the flash drive.

> ℹ️ BIOS/UEFI firmwares are very different depending of your computer/motherboard. You can find more specific help for yours when searching online for your motherboard or computer model name.

Windows 11 Setup

Once you've booted from your flash drive, you should see a window titled "Windows 11 Setup".

Follow the on-screen instructions and select your preferred parameters.

> ❗ While this guide gives the general steps of setting up Windows, your setup might be different. Always make sure to read all of what's written on your screen, as you may want to do something differently than on this guide for personal preferences.

It should go similarly to this:

- Selecting language settings (language, time and currency) ;
- Selecting keyboard settings (input method) ;
- Selecting setup option. Make sure to select "Install Windows 11" ;

> ❗ Everything on the drive you'll install Windows on will be deleted! Files, apps, settings, and more. Cancel everything if you wish to save them.

- Adding (or skipping) product key:
  - If you have one, enter it here ;
  - Else, click "I don't have a product key" ;
- Selecting image. I'd recommend selecting Windows 11 Pro, or whichever product key you intend to buy later (if you intend to buy one) ;

> ℹ️ The "N" versions do not include some essential media handling components and are not recommended to install. If you choose to install an "N" version, you should still able to get back all these features by following this guide.

- Accepting (after carefully reading, of course) the applicable notices and licenses terms ;
- Deleting any partition that might be present on your disk. Then selecting it and clicking "Next" ;
- Clicking "Install" when it says "Ready to install" ;
- Waiting for Windows' installation.

Windows 11 OOBE (Out Of the Box Experience)

Once it finishes, you access to a new (more modern) interface, with, again, on-screen instructions to follow.

> ❗ While this guide gives the general steps of installing Windows, your installation might be different. Always make sure to read all of what's written on your screen, as you may want to do something differently than on this guide for personal preferences.

It should go similarly to this:

- Selecting your country or region ;
- Selecting your keyboard layout ;

When it asks you to connect to a network, don't plug your Ethernet cable in or connect to a Wi-Fi network. Instead:

- Press Shift + F10 ;
- Click on the terminal window that appears ;
- Type in "oobe\bypassnro" and Enter ;
- The setup should restart and once you get back to the network section, you should see a new "I don't have internet" option. Click on it ;

Back to the instructions:

- If you are eligible (IR camera or fingerprint reader), setting up Windows Hello ;
- Creating a PIN code ;

Then, Windows will ask you to "Choose privacy settings". It is recommended to disable all of them to limit data sharing, tracking, and personalized advertising.

Back to the instructions:

- Clicking "Skip" when asked to customize your experience (this is unnecessary) ;
- Setting up or skipping phone linking ;
- Declining commercial offers such as Microsoft 365, Cloud storage/OneDrive, or the XBOX/PC Game Pass.

You should finally access Windows 11's desktop.

Final note

This guide will be updated in the future to address some unclear parts, and to include a guide on what you should do once Windows is installed.

Thanks for your understanding :)